initiated. Zahgir had been named an offender in the murder, but he continued to evade arrest. A sympathetic lawyer was needed to defend Syed Sarwar, Mohammad Aslam Wani and Zahoor Shahdad, all of whom were behind bars. Afzal Beg was an excellent lawyer who had previously defended himself in the Kashmir Conspiracy Case. He had his own reasons to partner with Al-Fatah, despite the obvious risks of associating with Zahgir.

Praveen Swami has revealed that Abdul Rashid Dar was put in charge of maintaining contact with Beg, both to discuss the defence of the Al-Fatah members and to frame a common programme of political agitation. Soon after the Pulwama robbery, Zahgir, Dar and Beg held another meeting, this time in the Chashm-e-Shahi gardens on the banks of the Dal Lake in Srinagar. This time Afzal Beg had matters other than the law to discuss. General elections were due in 1971, and the Jammu and Kashmir Legislative Assembly elections were due in 1972. The 1967 elections had made it clear to Beg that the Plebiscite Front ran the risk of being marginalised.

What Beg and Zahgir never realised was that all their meetings were under surveillance of the security arms of the Indian state. Apparently, at another meeting on 14 November 1970, Afzal Beg finally told Zahgir that the Plebiscite Front was ready to contest the coming elections and that he was principally worried of the Congress party rigging the elections. One major concern was booth-capturing and its corollary of stuffing ballot boxes. Beg wanted the SF and YML to help the Plebiscite Front secure a respectable showing by being polling booth vigilantes. Beg, in parting, asked Zahgir if he had any message to pass on to the Pakistan High Commission, where he was scheduled for a visit the next month. Zahgir did not take up the offer because he did not want to expose his own links.

Praveen Swami goes on to relate a gripping account of how, in order to augment their supply of cash, Al-Fatah planned another robbery. Nazir Ahmad Wani identified Jammu and Kashmir Bank’s Hazratbal branch as the target. The execution of the robbery was superlative—the payday for government employees fell on 2 January 1971 and it was on that day that